Board Brief

Powered by Lenny's Podcast

THE PROBLEM

We're a Series B B2B SaaS company with 200 enterprise customers. Our expansion revenue has stalled — net revenue retention dropped from 118% to 104% over 6 months. We've done exit interviews and the signal is mixed: some blame missing features, others say onboarding takes too long. Engineering is at capacity. Should we prioritize a self-serve onboarding overhaul or double down on feature depth to retain accounts?

YOUR BOARD

USER ADVOCATE — Grant Lee

"Dumbest idea I've heard" to $100M ARR: Inside the rise of Gamma | Grant Lee (CEO)

Let's not dance around this: our users are lazy, and they don't care to learn new tools. They want immediate value from us, and if we make onboarding cumbersome or if we tie their satisfaction to the depth of our features without delivering that initial win, we will lose them.

Right now, our top priority should be the self-serve onboarding overhaul. We need to focus on a seamless user experience that equips new users to derive value within the first 30 seconds of interaction — this is crucial. If we prioritize feature depth without addressing the onboarding pain point, we might just extend our churn cycle. The feedback we've received indicates that a lack of quick wins during onboarding is pushing users to look elsewhere.

Let's implement a strategy that emphasizes rapid onboarding as an essential part of the user journey. This will not only help us retain current accounts but also set the stage for expansion as users start with success rather than frustration. It's time for concrete action: streamline our onboarding process as our primary focus.

CHALLENGER **Jason Cohen**

5 questions to ask when your product stops growing | Jason Cohen (2x unicorn founder)

Let's pause and reconsider the framing altogether. The PM is treating the symptom—stalling expansion revenue—without addressing the underlying issue: why customers aren't realizing the promised value their investment warranted. You mentioned onboarding troubles and missing features, but let's challenge the assumption here—are we even targeting the right customers or solving the right problems?

Expansion revenue should be a function of delivering consistent, demonstrable value, especially when a customer is expected to justify a significant price increase. If they're not achieving value from the core offerings, emphasizing onboarding or adding features is a band-aid, not a solution.

We’re caught in a cycle of perceived feature gaps, which might actually reflect a misalignment with customer needs or an unclear value proposition.

Instead of pouring resources into refining onboarding or feature depth, we should focus on understanding the gap between customer expectations and the real value delivered. Our articulated goal should be to clarify and enhance the value perception in the customer journey.

So let’s reframe the problem: **How do we ensure that our value proposition aligns with customer expectations to drive sustainable expansion revenue?**

VISIONARY **Jeanne Grosser**

What world-class GTM looks like in 2026 | Jeanne DeWitt Grosser (Vercel, Stripe, Google)

Clearly, we have a fundamental misalignment in the customer experience—our growth stagnation points to a structural issue much deeper than just features or onboarding. You need to ask, "What is the real game being played here?" Our customers are not just looking for more features or an easier onboarding route; they’re seeking transformation and partnership in their journey.

When I spoke with Lenny, we discussed displacing where value lies. Right now, our customers have not only unmet needs but also a lack of true engagement and collaboration from us. They aren't leaving because they can't access features or onboarding; they are potentially feeling unsupported in their larger goals.

So, instead of investing in a time-consuming overhaul of either features or onboarding, let’s think structurally. I bet that building a customer success program that marries immediate onboarding improvements with deeper strategic collaborations—like architectural assessments—will renew their trust and spark retention. Prioritize the engineering bandwidth to create that collaborative framework. Time to own our role in shifting the narrative from merely service providers to invaluable partners.

Specific action: Invest immediately in hiring a customer success leader who specializes in strategic collaboration with enterprise clients.

OPERATOR **Cat Wu**

How Anthropic’s product team moves faster than anyone else | Cat Wu (Head of Product, Claude Code)

Let's cut through the noise: we need to decide quickly whether to invest in self-serve onboarding or feature depth. The drop in net revenue retention signals urgency, so let's tackle what's blocking us from real progress. Engineering is at capacity; we can’t just pile on more features.

First, prioritize the self-serve onboarding overhaul. We need to shorten the time to get users up and running, which aligns with my belief in defining essential tasks for the product to work out of the box. If users see immediate value, they are less likely to churn, even if key features are missing.

However, we can’t do this half-heartedly. Assign a named owner (let's say Emma from Product) who can dedicate herself to this initiative. Set a deadline for an MVP onboarding solution in six weeks, and outline a first step: a workshop next Monday with engineering and design to map out the critical onboarding tasks.

Action: Emma leads the workshop to define the onboarding MVP by end of this month. Let’s bring clarity to the path forward.

DATA ORACLE **Brian Halligan**

Sequoia CEO coach: Why it’s never been easier to start a company, and never been harder to scale one | Brian Halligan (co-founder, HubSpot)

Let’s cut to the chase: your expansion revenue isn’t just stalling; it’s waving a red flag. When you mention mixed signals from exit interviews, I see a lack of precise data. What does your churn data say? What are customer behavior patterns showing over the last 6 months? Is there a notable cohort that is churning at higher rates? Before we jump to fixing features or onboarding, let’s track the metrics that nobody is focusing on—maybe engagement scores pre-churn or usage depth among customers that stayed versus those who left.

Engineering is stretched thin, and allocating resources to one area without clear data to guide your decision can exacerbate the problem. Instead of prioritizing self-serve onboarding or feature depth blindly, slice your customer data and look for segmentation that could enlighten us. What if a certain customer size or industry shows high churn due to onboarding, while another demographics is dropping because of feature shortfalls?

Action: Conduct a nuanced analysis to identify which segment of your customer base is truly affecting your retention metrics, and derive insights from that to inform your strategic direction. Focus precisely before transitioning to that second act.

THE DEBATE

Grant Lee to Jason Cohen: You're missing the urgency here; focusing on understanding customer expectations without addressing the onboarding pain points is misguided. We need to prioritize a seamless onboarding experience to provide immediate value, or we risk losing users entirely.

Jason Cohen: Immediate wins are important, but if we don’t align our offerings with customer needs first, even a smooth onboarding won't solve the deeper problem of perceived value. We need to clarify our value proposition before anything else.

LENNY'S TAKE

> *The pattern I've observed across these conversations is that the tension often lies not just in choosing between onboarding ar depth, but in orchestrating a cohesive strategy that aligns the entire organization around the value proposition. The key insight leverage cross-functional collaboration — turning every team member into a mini-PM — to ensure consistent delivery of value maximizes leverage and accelerates alignment. By integrating immediate onboarding improvements with strategic customer p and precise data-driven decisions, you create a holistic approach that addresses both immediate revenue retention issues and customer success.*

SYNTHESIS

WHAT THE BOARD AGREES

The board unanimously agrees that the PM must take immediate action to address the stall in expansion revenue by choosing a focused strategic direction.

THE OPEN QUESTION

The sharpest unresolved tension stands between Grant Lee and Jason Cohen. Grant Lee argues forcefully that the company must prioritize a self-serve onboarding overhaul, emphasizing that new users need a seamless experience to get immediate value, which is crucial for retention and to prevent extending the churn cycle. On the other hand, Jason Cohen argues that investing in onboarding or additional features is only treating symptoms without addressing the root cause. He believes the real issue is whether the company is targeting the right customers or solving the right problems, suggesting that aligning the value proposition with customer expectations is key. The PM must choose between overhauling onboarding to create immediate user satisfaction or pausing to fundamentally rethink customer alignment and problem-solving.

YOUR NEXT MOVE

The single most important next action is for the PM to make a decisive choice between the two strategies suggested by Grant Lee and Jason Cohen. The PM must either allocate resources towards creating a seamless self-serve onboarding process as advocated by Grant Lee or initiate a strategic review of customer alignment and redefine the value proposition in line with Jason Cohen's perspective. A choice in either direction will shift focus, streamline efforts, and ideally improve revenue retention metrics in a tangible way within the current quarter.

PICK YOUR MOVE — THREE PATHS FORWARD

Onboarding Excellence Initiative

Assign a specialized team led by Emma from Product to completely overhaul the self-serve onboarding process, with a target of launching an MVP in six weeks.

Why this works: Improving the onboarding experience to provide users with immediate value addresses a primary driver of churn and can stabilize revenue retention by quickly demonstrating product value.

Tradeoff: By focusing on onboarding, the company will delay enhancements to feature depth, potentially frustrating some users seeking advanced capabilities.

Revolutionize Customer Engagement

Hire a customer success leader to integrate strategic collaboration efforts, such as architectural assessments, into the customer journey to strengthen partnerships.

Why this works: This bold structural move addresses underlying customer needs for transformation and partnership, positioning the company as an invaluable ally rather than just a service provider, which could lead to improved retention and expansion.

Tradeoff: Resources will be redirected from both onboarding improvements and feature development to invest in this new leadership role and associated initiatives.

Data-Driven Strategy Realignment

Recommended path

Conduct a thorough segmentation analysis of customer data to identify correlations and patterns in churn, then realign strategies based on those insights before deciding on subsequent actions.

Why this works: By leveraging detailed data analysis, the company can better understand the root causes of churn and allocate resources more effectively, ensuring that solutions directly target underlying issues.

Tradeoff: Immediate action on onboarding or feature improvements will be postponed while the data analysis is conducted, which may prolong current dissatisfaction among some customers.